THE FOUR-ADVENTURE EDITION / FOUR REMARKABLE OUTINGS

The Unordinary Four

Four excellent reasons to get out and try something new.

Four carefully chosen ways to do something different: a live-actor carnival, a Wonderland puzzle quest, a coached flying lap and a river expedition to save for the warmer months.



Original editorial artwork. Imagined collage, not an actual landscape or documentary venue photograph.

THE MYSTERIOUS ONE · EAST DIDSBURY

Escape the Creepy Carnival

A fairground that comes alive after dark is an excellent setting for an escape-room challenge. At Houdini’s Creepy Carnival, the aim is not simply to open a few padlocks. Your group must work through a deliberately spooky story, gather objects, interpret clues and find a way out before the hour is up.



Original editorial illustration. Imagined scene, not an actual venue photograph or navigational route.

What makes it different

Houdini’s frames the game around a long-abandoned carnival and a fictional disappearance. Eerie music and performers are part of the experience, alongside puzzles that depend on people paying attention to different details. The attraction advertises live actors and unexpected scares, so this is one to choose deliberately, not a surprise booking for someone who dislikes horror.

ESCAPE THE CREEPY CARNIVAL

Plan the adventure

The experience

The appeal is how quickly a group changes from curious spectators into a team. One person may spot a symbol while somebody else joins the dots; another keeps track of what has been tried. You do not need to know the answers in advance, and the best group discussion afterwards is about how you approached the challenge without giving its secrets away.

Try this: Before entering, agree who will keep an eye on the time, who likes visual clues and who enjoys word or number puzzles. Roles can change once the game begins. Afterwards, compare which kind of clue helped you move forward.

How to make it happen

01 Choose the right game
Book
Creepy Carnival
specifically at Houdini's, within Tenpin at Parrs Wood. The operator accepts groups of two to eight.

02 Check the scare and age rules
It features live actors. Players aged 12–16 need a paying adult in the game; older teenagers have separate supervision and waiver conditions.

03 Compare the real total
The advertised £75 Wednesday deal covers up to six players only with code MIDBREAK, subject to exclusions and availability. Other dates and group sizes vary.

04 Keep the surprises intact
After the game, discuss your teamwork without spoiling the puzzles for a future group.

The essentials

WHERE
East Didsbury

TIME
60-minute game

PRICE
Price varies by date and group. Published Wednesday offer: £75 for up to six with code MIDBREAK; restrictions apply.

BEST FOR
Groups of 2–8; ages 12+. The game includes live actors and scares.

AVAILABILITY
Advance booking; check date-specific availability.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Scary live actors and sensory effects may make this unsuitable for some readers. Confirm access needs, age supervision, booking terms and the actual checkout price before you pay.

Why choose it?

Choose this if your group wants a shared story, a little fear and something to talk about afterwards.

Official details: https://www.houdinisescape.co.uk/locations/manchester-parrs-wood/creepy-carnival/
Venue map: Open map

THE CURIOUS ONE · HULME

Rescue the Mad Hatter's guests

A tea party is ready, but its guests have vanished. In this Z-arts experience, your group steps into a theatrical Wonderland environment and sets off with a digital tablet. The mission is to follow a trail of clues and bring the missing characters back before the seventy-five minutes run out.



Original editorial illustration. Imagined scene, not an actual venue photograph or navigational route.

What makes it different

It is part escape-room puzzle, part scavenger hunt and part interactive game. Instead of sitting through a show, you explore the environment, handle challenges and decide what each new clue means. Z-arts says you meet the Mad Hatter by the riverbank at the start, and other teams may be exploring the wider space at the same time while following their own route.

RESCUE THE MAD HATTER'S GUESTS

Plan the adventure

The experience

The experience is designed for families, but it does not require the adults to pretend they are merely accompanying the children. Spotting visual details, remembering story fragments and testing theories are all useful. A mixed-age group can play to different strengths, which makes the adventure particularly appealing for an unusual family celebration.

Try this: Let a different person lead each stage: clue hunter, tablet navigator, story detective and final decision-maker. See whether the person who notices the most details is also the person who solves the final riddle.

How to make it happen

01 Book the exact experience
Select
Mission: Mad Hatter
rather than the separate general Adventures in Wonderland visit.

02 Bring the right team
The normal format is three to six players with at least one adult. It is designed for ages 9+, although Z-arts allows children aged 7+ in family teams.

03 Follow the clues
Collect the tablet, explore the decorated space and solve a mix of physical and digital puzzles.

04 Make it a whole outing
Allow time to get into Hulme and meet the booked start time. Ask Z-arts about accessibility adaptations before purchasing.

Official details: https://www.z-arts.org/events/mission-mad-hatter/
Venue map: Open map

The essentials

WHERE
Hulme

TIME
75-minute adventure

PRICE
From £19 per player in the organiser's launch information; verify the live booking total.

BEST FOR
Teams of 3–6 including at least one adult. Designed for ages 9+; children aged 7+ may join a family team.

AVAILABILITY
Book a specific Mission: Mad Hatter session.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

The organiser's £19 starting price comes from its April 2026 launch announcement. Session prices and availability must be confirmed at checkout. Booking transfers have notice requirements and may involve fees.

Why choose it?

Choose this for an imaginative family challenge that needs cooperation rather than competitive speed.

THE FAST ONE · EAST MANCHESTER

Ride a flying lap in a real velodrome

The banked curves of Manchester's National Cycling Centre look very different from an ordinary cycle path. The experience offers the chance to try a proper fixed-wheel track bike inside a purpose-built velodrome, under the direction of an instructor, rather than watching the action from the stands.



Original editorial illustration. Imagined scene, not an actual venue photograph or navigational route.

What makes it different

Your session starts with fitting equipment and learning the basics. You watch a briefing, meet the coach and get accustomed to the track bike before progressing around the banking. The aim is to build control and confidence, not to pretend you have suddenly become a professional racer. That distinction matters: a normal cyclist can be new to velodrome riding, but cannot be new to riding a bicycle altogether.

RIDE A FLYING LAP IN A REAL VELODROME

Plan the adventure

The experience

The finale is a timed flying lap, which gives the experience a satisfying finish. There is something unusually memorable about seeing the track from a rider's perspective and then having a real number to take home. It is also a strong choice for somebody who enjoys skill-based challenges more than rides or passive attractions.

Try this: Pay attention to one technical detail your coach teaches, perhaps how you look through a corner or how a fixed-wheel bike feels. Afterwards, write down your lap time and what made the banking easier to understand.

How to make it happen

01 Choose the correct booking
Book the National Cycling Centre's **Velodrome Experience**, not a separate accreditation or BMX session.

02 Check your suitability
You must be at least 12 years old, at least 145 cm tall and able to ride an ordinary two-wheeled bike unaided.

03 Learn from the coach
The organiser supplies a track bike, helmet and cleated shoes. It begins with fitting and safety instruction.

04 Finish with the flying lap
The 90-minute session builds towards a timed lap. Book a suitable available date and follow the instructor's directions throughout.

Official details: https://www.nationalcyclingcentre.com/experiences
Venue map: Open map

The essentials

WHERE
East Manchester

TIME
90-minute coached experience

PRICE
£50 per person on the organiser's current published page; bike, helmet and cleated shoes included.

BEST FOR
Ages 12+, at least 145 cm tall, already able to cycle unaided and fit enough for an hour's cycling.

AVAILABILITY
Advance-book a Velodrome Experience slot.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Participants should have enough fitness for approximately an hour of cycling. Venue-specific access and suitability questions should be raised before booking. East Manchester is an intentional destination outside Radar's core neighbourhoods.

Why choose it?

Choose this if you want an achievable first-timer challenge with a distinctive sporting finish.

THE OUTDOORS ONE · HEATON MERSEY → NORTHENDEN

Kayak the Mersey and tackle the waterslide

The Mersey is an unlikely place to picture a mini-expedition. Yet Venture Out's Short Splash turns a stretch of river between Heaton Mersey and Northenden into a memorable adventure, with shallow rapids early on, river bends to negotiate and a waterslide weir near the finish.



Original editorial illustration. Imagined scene, not an actual venue photograph or navigational route.

What makes it different

The operator describes a 5.5 km trip that takes roughly one to one-and-a-half hours on the water. You can book an eligible self-guided sit-on-top kayak or ask about guided options with other craft. There is a briefing and safety equipment; which conditions and routes are appropriate are decisions for the operator, not for a reader to judge from an illustration.

KAYAK THE MERSEY AND TACKLE THE WATERSLIDE

Plan the adventure

The experience

An important practical detail makes this a proper point-to-point outing: the company collects its boats at Northenden, but it does not transport the people back to Heaton Mersey. That means arranging a lift, leaving a suitable car at the finish or organising a taxi before you set off. A spare change of clothes is sensible, and the launch and exit may involve steps. Plan it for the usual April-to-September season rather than treating it as an autumn drop-in.

Try this: Make the logistics part of the adventure. Before booking, work out who is travelling with you, where you will finish, how you will return and what dry clothes you will need. Then let the organiser judge whether the river is suitable on your chosen day.

How to make it happen

01 Save it for the right season

Regular public river dates normally run weekends April–September. Contact Venture Out about other dates, which may be possible by arrangement.

02 Choose the right craft

The operator lists £20 for an adult self-guided single sit-on-top kayak to Northenden; check current prices, other craft and eligibility.

03 Listen to the river briefing

The route includes bends and the operator's described waterslide weir. River levels can change the trip or cause postponement.

04 Arrange your own return

The Short Splash finishes at Riverside Park, Northenden. Venture Out collects boats, not passengers. Arrange transport before starting.

Official details: https://www.venture-out.co.uk/mersey-short-splash
Venue map: Open map

The essentials

WHERE
Heaton Mersey → Northenden

TIME
About 1–1½ hours on the water, plus briefing and independent return journey.

PRICE
Officially listed at £20 for an adult, self-guided single sit-on-top kayak to Northenden; other options cost more.

BEST FOR
Adults and families who are comfortable following water-safety guidance; suitability depends on craft, ability and river conditions.

AVAILABILITY
Regular trips on weekends April–September; other dates by arrangement.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

SEASONAL: regular trips April–September, other dates by arrangement. River levels may lead to changes or cancellation. Wear the required buoyancy aid and helmet, and discuss any medical, swimming or accessibility needs with the operator. The illustrated river is not a navigational or safety guide.

Why choose it?

Choose this for an outdoors challenge that feels much further from the city than it actually is, provided you book an appropriate operator-run trip.

A NOTE FOR READERS

Good plans start with good information.

These are four real experiences, but this is a **independent editorial guide**. Operators change their dates, charges, minimum ages and access arrangements. Check the original booking page before making plans.

The five things we checked

- Creepy Carnival is a 60-minute, actor-led escape experience for groups of 2–8, ages 12+.
- Mission: Mad Hatter is a 75-minute family puzzle quest for teams of 3–6, with one adult in each team.
- The velodrome experience is coached and finishes with a timed flying lap. It requires existing cycling ability.
- Venture Out's Short Splash is a river trip, not a self-directed public path or a normal autumn walk-in.
- All illustrations are conceptual. They do not show actual interiors or demonstrate safe water conditions.

Kayaking is seasonal. Regular weekend trips are normally April–September. The operator collects the boats, not the passengers, at the Northenden finish.

About the reward: This four-adventure edition is the current South Manchester Radar referral reward for one eligible new reader. It is a standalone collection; a longer edition is not promised.

Primary venue links and evidence are included in the editable source pack. Information reviewed 28 October 2026.